

Working Paper



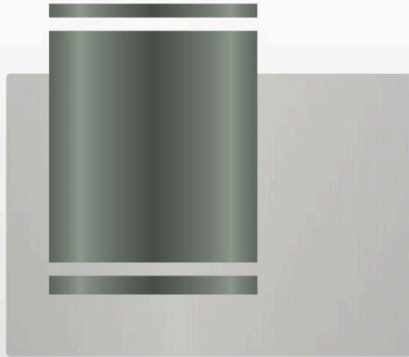
A THEORETICAL EXAMINATION OF THE POLITICAL ECONOMY OF MEDIA

Olufunlola Arowolo, Ph.D.

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Abstract

This paper outlines and defines the essence of the Political Economy of Media theory as outlined by Karl Marx, the originator of the concept. Primary concepts and models are examined along with detractors of this theory. A real world application of the theory is also presented in this study with the goal of reinforcing the significance of the theory to the field of mass communication, in general, and to media theories, specifically.

1. Introduction

The political economy theory of mass media was conceptually birthed by the renowned philosopher, Karl Marx, around the 18th century. Nicholas Garnham (1979) followed Marx's lead and further expanded upon the main concepts of the theory, in his work entitled *Contributions to a Political Economy of Mass Communication*. It was Dennis McQuail, a scholar in the late 1980s, who conceptualized the term political economy. He wrote extensively on the issue in his book entitled *Mass Communication Theory*. McQuail (1987) explained that the consequences of media institutional monopolies can be seen in the reduction of independent media sources; the resource concentration on larger markets; the avoidance of risk taking; and, the neglect of smaller and poorer sectors of potential audience members (p. 64). Garnham (1979) further expanded the tenets of the theory by proposing the notion that media ownership is synonymous with economic power.

Traditionally, media theories tend to focus on the ideological content of media, and on how said content affects the viewer. However, the political economy of media theory places emphasis on the economic structure of society; and, proposes that media ideology is dependent on the economic base that sustains it. The theory focuses research attention on empirical analyses of ownership structures, and also pays attention to the manner in which media market forces operate. From the political economy theoretical standpoint, the media, as an institution, is considered part of the economy, with close ties to the political system (Garnham, 1979; McQuail, 1987).

Economic structures hinge on profitability – profitability is a feature of media enterprises – much like any other commercial institution. The quest for profitability in the media industry is closely vested in the success of other commercial industries, owing to both vertical and horizontal integration (McQuail, 1987) – e.g., software advancement must succeed for satellite radio to thrive.

According to Murdock and Golding (1977), the effects of economic forces are not random but work consistently to exclude:

[T]hose voices lacking economic power or resources...the underlying logic of cost operates systematically, consolidating the position of groups already established in the main mass-media markets and excluding those groups who lack the capital base

required for successful entry. Thus the voices which survive will largely belong to those least likely to criticize the prevailing distribution of wealth and power. Conversely, those most likely to challenge these arrangements are unable to publicize their dissent or opposition because they cannot command resources needed for effective communication to a broad audience (p. 37).

In other words, marginalized social groups are usually powerless in the face of economic media giants – eventually, the voices of these marginalized groups go unrepresented in the mass-media arena. Marginalized groups attempting to go against the elitist grain will likely see their efforts thwarted by media conglomerates wielding strategic economic resources, which allow them to gain significant social and political ground, with access to a wide audience. Profit maximization will motivate media firms to indulge partisan audiences by censoring information that does not align with partisan narratives, resulting in “...important information [being] lost through bias...[and] giv[ing] rise to...heightened political polarization and asymmetric distributions of...ideologies...” (Bernhardt, Krasa, & Polborn, 2006, p. 1092).

2. A Holistic Approach to the Political Economy of Media Theory

When considering theories of political economy, the economic perspective tends to overshadow the political. In other words, the market is usually the primary unit of analysis; political and other social activities emanate from the market (Duhé & Sriramesh, 2007/8, pp. 3-5). In order to successfully assess a country’s media environment and social structures Sriramesh and Verçiç (2003) contend that infrastructural variables – e.g., a nation’s political system; its level of economic development; and, its level of activism – and the critical relationships between them should be identified and understood. Duhé and Sriramesh (2007/8) argued that it is not necessary to categorize political and economic systems separately because a political economy perspective offers a holistic view of the interrelatedness between political, economic, and social factors.

2.1. Defining the Term ‘Political Economy’

Gilpin (2001) defines *global political economy* as “the interaction of the market and such powerful actors as states, multinational firms, and international organizations” (pp. 17-18). A political economy, on a microscopic level, is a microcosm of legal, social, economic, and policymaking machines. The political economy of media theory examines how this microcosm of dynamic interactions empowers actors that wield economic influence, establish corporate ownership, and shape policy and political dialogue in the media sector.

Smythe (1977) proposes that political economy of media theories center the media as a structural economic process that ultimately produces commodities (content). Said content affects all spheres of the socioeconomic and sociopolitical environment of their audiences. Smythe suggested that an interesting variant of the theory is that media truly produces its own audience because media outlets – in delivering audience attention to advertisers – shape the economic/buying behavior of their publics.

Oftentimes, media powerhouses are divided by political points of view (which are heavily reinforced through programming geared towards calcifying support among viewers). Duhé and Sriramesh (2007/8) alluded to the interconnectedness between politics and economics (p. 3) by examining Caparaso and Levine's (1992) statement that, during the 18th century, *want satisfaction* became an increasingly political concept, as the evolution of the nature of wants, the means of production, and the modes of distribution meant individuals became increasingly dependent on people outside of their familial bonds to sustain and maintain both their livelihoods and economic well-being.

Caparaso and Levine (1992) explained that the overall proper functioning of want satisfaction systems is the responsibility of the heads of state (as opposed to the head of the household) – the authors suggest that this is the reason many early writings in classical political economy pay heavy attention to the role governments play in satisfying social wants. Caparaso and Levine (1992) described four major schools of political economy thought: Classical, Marxian, Neoclassical, and Keynesian – with the assertion that each school is the result of evolutionary changes/direct responses to corresponding historical events and societal concerns.

2.1.1. The Classical Political Economy

The classical school of political economy dates back to the 18th and 19th centuries (Duhé and Sriramesh, 2007, pp. 7). Adam Smith (1776), also known as the Father of Economics, described the political economy as “the nature and causes of the wealth of nations” (p. 679). Smith believed that society was best served when each individual pursued his/her own highest good, and posited that the role of the government should be limited to three areas – national defense, justice and public works – because, according to Duhé and Sriramesh, these three areas render relatively miniscule benefit (in terms of profitability) to private suppliers in the market (2007/8, pp. 7). Classical theorists maintain that economic life can, and should, be separate from political and social activities (Caparaso & Levine, 1992) – the economy is viewed as a separate, apolitical entity.

2.1.2. The Marxian Political Economy

Karl Marx was one of the world's most influential socialist thinkers in the 19th Century - so much so that Marxism has played a pivotal role in critiques and analyses of the media, through the lens of the political economy (Burawoy, 1982). Be that as it may, Marx's ideas and theories only gained acceptance posthumously. Many of his ideas have been modified and have been applied and adapted to various political circumstances (Skocpol, 1980). Traditional Marxist views, whilst somewhat less dominant than in the mid 60's to mid 80's, found a restructured thought process into Neo-Marxist ideologies still influential in post-World War Two media research and theoretical applications (Burawoy, 1982).

Marxist theories have been portrayed as critical or radical – often portraying the role of the mass media as one that maintains the status quo of class dominance (Tickton, 2006). In contrast, liberal pluralists espouse non-Marxist views of media culture: Liberal Pluralists see the media as a system with a fairly certain degree of autonomy. From the pluralist viewpoint, not only is free speech paramount, a tier of management exists which allows a great deal of latitude to media professionals in their representations: Based on this freedom of latitude assumption, Jakubowicz (1998/99) posits that the relationship between media professionals and the audience is both equal and voluntary. On the other hand, Wetherly (2005) argued from a Classical Marxist position that the relationship between the economy and the media mimics a base-superstructure model wherein, the economy serves as the foundation (base) of society, and the media disseminates society's cultural and ideological viewpoints (superstructure) that validate the base's position.

The traditional Marxist view of the media is one of class domination: There is a constant battle of opinions; viewpoints fight for recognition within the domain of the dominant class. However, control is held by the capitalist, and media professionals are not only influenced but are also affected by the dominant culture. The media represents the ideology of the ruling class and the audience cannot recognize this influence because the audience itself is influenced by the dominant class (Wetherly, 2005).

Marx focused on how social issues (with economic undercurrents) triggered powerful political struggles (Caparaso and Levine, 1992) – however, Marx was not of the opinion that the capitalistic economy can form a nexus of inherently apolitical relationships. Marx framed economics as central to all “social, political, and spiritual processes of life” (Brennan, 1998, p. 263).

2.1.3. The Neoclassical Political Economy

Theories of political economy – which centered the neoclassical school of thought – emerged towards the end of the 19th century. Constrained choice and rational thought were two popular characteristics of the neoclassical school of thought. As explained by Caparaso and Levine (1992), within the political economy sphere, the economy is treated as a separate entity from politics: As economic agents seek to maximize their level of satisfaction within a limited range of choices, choice constraints allow for welfare to be maximized – since preferences are rank-ordered. The belief here is that leaving the market to its own devices will result in optimal social welfare, and the economic dynamic this fosters is that no one person is made better off without leaving someone else in a worse position (Duhé & Sriramesh, 2007/8, pp. 11). The neoclassical worldview makes a critical point of departure from the classical school of thought in the sense that the neoclassical school recognizes that markets can fail – in other words, markets will not always produce optimal results, when considering externalities, monopolies, or market system that prioritizes public goods (Caparaso & Levine, 1992).

2.1.4. Keynesian Political Economy

The Keynesian school of thought emerged during the early 20th century, and vigorously challenged the role assigned to the government by classical thinkers (Caparaso & Levine, 1992). John Maynard Keynes believed that government intervention was necessary in order to optimize resource allocation. Keynes aligned with Marx in observing that an individual's inability to find an appropriate outlet for his product in the market was not necessarily the result of a poor investment decision that needed adjustment but rather a failure on the part of the market to ensure adequate purchasing power and aggregate demand (Arize, Malindretos & Ghosh, 2015).

3. The Base and the Superstructure

According to Williams (1973), the ruling class (i.e., the bourgeoisie) own and control the media, and represent the superstructure of the media; whilst wealthy capitalists – or the base – control the economy. The superstructure controls the capitalist class.

Classical Marxism's key feature is economism – economism argues that the base of society determines everything else in the superstructure. However, the superstructure controls the base, through the media, legal, political, and economic structures (Williams, 1973).

Foster (2004) criticized classical approaches to economic theorizing as having promoted simplistic systems (based on constrained optimization that does not take diversity into consideration) over simple systems (which represent networks that create value by forging new connections). The author defines an economic system as a *complex adaptive system* - i.e., a system that: a) converts information to knowledge; b) establishes connections between systems; c) maintains structural irreversibility (stability that holds the network together); and, d) chronicles an identifiable historical time domain (maps actual processes as they unfold both within and external to the system).

According to Marxist fundamentalist tradition, the media, and its messages, are influenced by the economic base of the organization in which they are produced. The economic base thus represents a complex adaptive system (much like the media environment), in the sense that, the economic base is capable of: i) transforming information to knowledge (e.g., audience preferences); ii) creating connections between systems (e.g., connecting audiences to a political ad that solicits donations), iii) upholding the structural integrity of the system (e.g., self-organized structures with targeted ad campaigns), and iv) chronicling processes both internal and external to the system (e.g., measuring audience responsiveness to ads).

The downstream outcome of the superstructure's economic control over the base is that – within the context of media framing, even though the superstructure owns control of the media, it is the base (consisting of wealthy capitalists who own control of the economy) that wield heavier control on social, political, and intellectual consciousness, through influence on programming content they choose to fund - from inception to audience delivery.

Marxist proponents of the political economy see ideology as subordinate to the economic base. In Marxist terms, the mass media is the means through which the ruling class (who own and control the media) disseminates information and ideas to society without allowing opposition or alternative opinions (Wetherly, 2005). Therefore, owing to the level of socioeconomic and sociopolitical influence wielded by the superstructure, Wetherly (2005) posits that political and state institution-sponsored media outlets must show tendencies toward middle ground material.

3.1. Political Economy and the State

The state enjoys a certain level of autonomy – in the sense that, the state has the ability to define and pursue a public agenda independent of private societal interests (Caparaso & Levine, 1992). State centered approaches to political economy reflect the neoclassical view that all things political are public or associated with the state, and all things economic are associated with the private, or social sphere (Duhé & Sriramesh, 2007/8, pp. 11).

According to Gilpin (2001):

States set the rules that individual entrepreneurs and multinational forms must follow. Yet, economic and technological forces shape the policies and interests of individual states and the political relations among states. The market is indeed a potent force in determination of economic and political affairs. For this reason, both political and economic analyses are required to understand the actual functioning and evolution of the global economy (p. 24).

3.2. The Political Economy and its Interconnectedness with the Media

The term 'media' has an underlying implication of 'mediation.' Media (referring to its application both as a noun and as an adjective) serve to bridge the divide between the audience and the world. "Media are windows that enable us to see beyond our immediate surroundings, interpreters that help us make sense of experience, platforms or carriers that convey information ... filters that screen out parts of experience and focus on others, mirrors that reflect ourselves back to us and barriers that block the truth" (McQuail, 1987, pp. 52-53). Joshua Meyrowitz (1998), with the use of metaphors, describes the media as an 'environment' ... embedded into society and influencing larger social structures (pp. 61-62).

Media theory addresses three large thematic areas – media content and structure, society and culture, and audience (Littlejohn & Foss, 2005, p.275). A connection exists within these thematic areas that may be cyclical in nature: The audience absorbs media content. Media content then proceeds to shape and aid the audience in the formulation of perceptions. These perceptions will then tend to govern interactions on the social level thereby influencing certain aspects of culture. Maxwell and Tamara (1996) explain that the media have the potential for structuring issues for the public.

Lippman (1922), a prominent American journalist credited as the first to identify the potential the media has in structuring public issues explains that: "the public responds not to actual events in the environment but to "the picture in our heads," which he calls the *pseudoenvironment*: "For the real environment is all ... too complex ... too fleeting for direct acquaintance. We are not equipped to deal with so much subtlety, so much variety, so many permutations and combinations. (So) altogether we have to ...reconstruct (our environment) on a simpler model before we can manage it" (p. 16). The media and society (of which politics and economics play significant roles) are undeniably intertwined. The political-economic analysis of media lends us tools with which media structures and economics can be critiqued (McQuail, 1987).

3.3. Media Elites: Economic Power Wielders

In 1956, C. Wright Mills described a self-perpetuating establishment of corporate, military, legal, and political leaders he called the power elite. Among the emerging (or new) elites are public interest movements, a vastly expanded federal bureaucracy, and a national media network that serves as watchdog over other institutions (Lichter & Rothman, 1990, ix).

S. Robert Lichter and Stanley Rothman's (1990) writings illuminating the conflicts that take place between these strategic elites and trace their impact on American life. They highlight the role the new elites play in producing social and cultural change. Propaganda remains a popular weapon of choice (media effect) among this powerful few.

"To a degree that was hardly envisaged a generation ago, the major media stand at the center of the struggle for social influence. They act as the gatekeepers for the messages that contending groups and individuals wish to send to each other and to the general public" (Lichter & Rothman, 1990, x).

Lichter & Rothman (1990) examined the social, psychological, and political milieu of the national media, and the relationship between this milieu and news coverage of controversial social issues. Their findings record that social change in contemporary America is shaped by competition among elite groups

Lichter and Rothman's (1990) data suggest the following findings: (1) subjective elements are inherent in news coverage; (2) recent changes in American society and the journalistic profession have magnified these elements and shaped their direction; (3) as a result, the current intellectual and emotional milieu of the national media is expressed in news coverage of long-term social controversies. (p. 301).

Robert W. McChesney (1989) contends that:

Over the past generation, it has become increasingly clear to those on the left that the U.S. mass media, far from performing an autonomous and adversarial role in U.S. society, actively frame issues and promote news stories that serve the needs and concerns of the elite. Moreover, the importance of the leading corporate mass media in contemporary politics radically transcends the role of the mass media in earlier times. Hence, the Left has begun to pay considerable attention to how the media are structured and controlled and how they operate. Nevertheless, the ideology of the "free press" has proven to be a difficult adversary for left critics; as the media's operations are central to the modern polity, their legitimacy is shielded by layers and layers of ideological obfuscation (pp. 1).

4. The Political Economic Theory and the Marginalized Few

According to Robinson (1979): “The media have ignored minorities... broadcast messages reflect the virtual exclusion of minorities from the industry's decision-making and control process, as the Federal Communications Commission and others have noted” (p. 235). Robinson (1979) argues that the primary and most crucial obstacle confronting a prospective minority ownership of media is, of course, money. Financing is extremely difficult and lenders are averse to the highly regulated nature of the industry which is often the root cause for failure. However, money is not the only obstacle in the race for media ownership among the marginalized. As Robinson (1979) explains:

The problem is more complex and stems from the existence of a systematic series of barriers impeding minority ownership. These barriers may be divided into two groups: (1) obstructions that make it difficult for minorities to gain the prerequisites to media ownership- primarily inadequate experience and lack of financing; and (2) regulatory fetters that compound such problems, which primarily result from a general bias against any new entrant into the broadcasting industry (pp. 231).

According to Maynard Keynes, the aforementioned 20th century philosopher, government intervention was necessary in order to optimize resource allocation. The neoclassical view of the political economy of media theory suggests that leaving the market to its own devices will result in optimal social welfare because market conditions will self-regulate. The marginalized will attest to the fact that monopolistic nature of media control leaves their voices silenced. On the media balance scale the financial burden weighs in heavily on the side of the economically marginalized. The Marxian school of thought correctly illustrates that economic power solidifies media ownership which leads to dominance. Marginalized social groups may band together in effort against the media elite but it will be to no avail simply because they lack the economic resources to disrupt the dominant system.

5. Manufacturing Consent

As previously established, corporate news media can be described as a political economic entity. Economic in the sense that corporate media ownership rests in the hands of an elite few; and political in the sense that the powerful elite control messages that are broadcasted across the airwaves thus affecting the sociopolitical arena wherein these messages are received.

This lines up with the Marxian political economy, which upholds the notion that control is held by the capitalist, and media professionals are not only influenced but are also affected by the dominant culture. The media represent the ideology of the dominant class and the audience cannot recognize this influence because the audience itself is influenced by the dominant class (McChesney, 1989).

In *Manufacturing Consent*, by Edward S. Herman and Noam Chomsky (1988), a systematic "propaganda model" is used to describe corporate news media in the United States. They preface their discussion of the propaganda model by stating the belief that the mass media "serve to mobilize support for the special interests that dominate the state and private support for the special interests that dominate the state and private activity." Although propaganda is not the sole function of the media, it is "a very important aspect of their overall service" (p. xi), especially "in a world of concentrated wealth and major conflicts of class interest" (p.1).

Herman and Chomsky (1988) have written numerous articles and books that chronicle the ways in which the U.S. media have actively promoted the agenda of the elite, particularly in regard to U.S. activities in the Third World. *Manufacturing Consent* is a work of tremendous importance for scholars and activists alike (McChesney, 1989). According to Herman and Chomsky (1988):

Media bias arises from "the preselection of right-thinking people, internalized preconceptions, and the adaptation of personnel to the constraints" of a series of objective filters they present in their propaganda model. Hence the bias occurs largely through self-censorship, which explains the superiority of the U.S. mass media as a propaganda system: it is far more credible than a system which relies on official state censorship, although in performance the dominant media serve the agenda of the elite every bit as much as state organs do on behalf of the ruling bureaucracies in Eastern Europe.

The credibility and legitimacy of the media system is also preserved by the media's lack of complete agreement on all issues. Indeed, there is vigorous debate and dispute over many issues, as Herman and Chomsky readily acknowledge. They contend, however, that debate within the dominant media is limited to "responsible" opinions acceptable to some segment of the elite. On issues where the elite are in general consensus, the media will always toe the line. No dissent will then be countenanced, let alone acknowledged, except, when necessary for ridicule or derision (Herman and Chomsky, 1988).

This revisits the Marxist view of class domination in the media. There is a constant battle of opinions as viewpoints fight for recognition within the domain of the dominant class. Marx's focus on how social concerns that had an economic nature triggered powerful political struggles can be applied to Herman and Chomsky's (1988) reasoning that debates within the dominant media is limited to "responsible" opinions acceptable to some segment of the elite; and that on issues where the elite are in general consensus, the media will always toe the line (McChesney, 1989).

Herman and Chomsky (1988) perceive the media elite fundamentally in class terms, i.e. is it best understood as being composed of capitalists and the highest level managers of advanced capitalism (McChesney, 1989).

5.1. Manufacturing Consent: The Five Filters

In their propaganda model, Herman and Chomsky (1988) present a series of five "filters" to account for why the media invariably serve as propagandists for the interests of the elite and perhaps as proponents of the political economic approach to media theory. It was noted that only stories with a strong orientation to elite interests can pass through the five filters unobstructed and receive ample media attention. The model also explains how the media can conscientiously function when even a superficial analysis of the evidence would indicate the nature of many of the stories that receive ample publicity in the press and on the network news broadcasts (McChesney, 1989).

According to McChesney (1989), ownership of media content is the first filter that influences media content - ownership is niche, highly concentrated among a few dozen of the largest for-profit corporations across the globe. McChesney explains that, oftentimes, several corporations with media ownership titles usually have expansive portfolios in other industries and countries. This means profitability is king and rules all aspects of decision-making, including news operations and media content delivery. McChesney posits that the conflict of interest emerges when self-governed media systems are controlled by a handful of corporations, motivated by profit.

McChesney (1989) categorizes advertising as the second filter, which the author describes as having dominated the U.S. mass media and is the main source of income generation for the media. Herman and Chomsky (1988), examined evidence related to the effect of profit-seeking activities on media content - they concluded that profit maximization and the need to satisfy advertiser interests drives how the media presents news content.

McChesney (1989) identifies the third filter as sourcing, which details the heavy influence powerful institutions have on content deemed newsworthy. Herman and Chomsky (1988) explain that "the mass media are drawn into a symbiotic relationship with powerful sources of information by economic necessity and reciprocity of interest" (p. 14).

McChesney posits that the media relies heavily on news provided to them by corporate and government sources (1989). Corporate and government sources, through information subsidies, maintain sizable bureaucracies to provide content to the media - these subsidies also allow for cost reduction (via pre-packaged news) (Gandy, 1982). McChesney explains that because corporate and government bureaucracies subsidize the media, the media is almost obligated to oblige their content. Further, these corporate and government sources are inherently credible, based on widely accepted journalistic standards; thus, anti-elite sources have difficulty accessing this niche space, and are treated with a high level of scrutiny (McChesney, 1989).

Herman and Chomsky (1988) describe the fourth filter as “the development of right-wing corporate “flak” producers ... to harass the mass media and to put pressure upon them to follow the corporate agenda” (pp. 26-28). Herman and Chomsky explain that flak machines are both antagonistic to the media, and represent discipline, in the sense that they generate opposing viewpoints to media programming (lawsuits, phone calls, etc.) - antagonism which, in order to move the needle, can only be sustained by wealthy elites. The final filter centers on anticommunism, which Herman and Chomsky (1988) presented as an ideological means of controlling public opinion. McChesney (1989) posits that anticommunism is so entrenched in United States journalistic practices that, even when “detente” reigns, journalists can present antagonistic viewpoints about communist ideology, without fear of backlash or public repudiation.

5.2. The ‘Real World’ Application

Manufacturing Consent by Herman and Chomsky (1988) is made up of case studies wherein the authors analyze the validity of the propaganda model for explaining the political and economic overtones present in the media coverage of five major sets of news stories. Herman and Chomsky present the facts in each case and then thoroughly dissect the treatment of the story by several elite media outlets: The New York Times, Time, Newsweek, and CBS News. Each chapter is meticulously researched and most draw heavily on the authors' earlier works (McChesney, 1989).

Herman and Chomsky posited that the propaganda model highlights “worthy victims” and “unworthy victims,” depending upon their relationship to elite interests: Media coverage is extensive and of outrage for the former, while it is generally unsympathetic, if it exists at all, for the latter (1988, p. 38).

McChesney (1989) reveals how early 1980s media coverage of the elections in Guatemala, El Salvador, and Nicaragua exactly as one would anticipate from the propaganda model.

5.2.1. The Watergate Affair

The expression "Watergate" refers to the political scandal that forced Richard Nixon to resign the presidency (Herman and Chomsky, 1988). Washington, D.C, police arrested five burglars who had just broken into the Democratic National Committee (DNC) headquarters at the Watergate apartment and office complex on June 17, 1972, and Nixon resigned on August 9, 1974: Between those two dates emerged the progressive revelation of illegal campaign practices, presidential abuses of power, illegal wiretapping, Internal Revenue Service pressure, harassment of alleged political enemies, and president-directed obstruction of justice to conceal from federal investigators these and other illegal acts (Herman and Chomsky, 1988). The crisis preoccupied President Nixon, his closest aides – and ultimately, Congress, the courts, the press, and the public. The scandal – which gave rise to several showdowns between the executive and the legislature, and also between the executive and the judiciary – is regarded as one of the more important constitutional crises in U.S. history (Schudson, 1998).

Herman and Chomsky (1988) explain that the Watergate affair – an investigation which the free press upheld as ‘defending the constitution and bringing down a corrupt regime’ – became a major issue for media representatives during the investigative process (p. 297). The scandal conformed to the propaganda model as an example of the media responding to a crisis among the elite. The authors discuss the limitations of the corporate media system in a democratic society and bring to the foreground the elitist grip on the dissemination of information (McChesney, 1989). The role of the media in the midst of this crisis, and the battle it underwent with the White House (a powerful economic and political entity), serves as an illustration of the political economy of media theory as it applies to real world situations.

5.2.2. Hypothetical Application

Several critical theorists (Marx, 1998; Adorno & Horkheimer, 2002; Althusser, 1971; Herman & Chomsky, 1988) support the theoretical underpinnings of the political economy of media, which suggest that media can be, and usually are, instruments of ruling class ideology in society. Dominating ideals take root and grow without opposition because the elite group commands economic power. The dominant ideologies of the ruling class permeate the airwaves and seep into public sentiments, with the ultimate aim of either forming new opinions among viewers or crystalizing extant viewpoints.

Media elitists hold power in the sense that their subjective perspectives may serve to lend credence to the issues propelled by the media. But what if this ‘elite’ media society is misinformed? What if they are misguided about a certain subject?

What if their ideas on crucial social issues are miscommunicated – or misrepresented by journalists and reporters, who serve as crucial links between the audience and the content? What if the content chosen by this elite group is misunderstood by the intended audience?

By analyzing the kinds of information various audiences have consumed, and by tracing the ways in which they acquired that knowledge and fitted it into their lives... several dimensions of the information and communication revolution can be both analyzed and clarified (Brown, 1989).

6. Concluding Thoughts

The five filters outlined by Herman and Chomsky (1988) – through the lens of the political economic approach to media theory – provide insight on how media invariably serve as propagandists for the ruling class. A future study would do well in revisiting the notion established by the first filter, which contends that media content is highly subject to ownership, and that ownership is, in turn, highly concentrated among a few dozen of the largest for-profit corporations in the world: Because many of these corporations tend to have extensive holdings in other industries and nations, objectively, profit-seeking behaviors severely influence news operations, and the overall content generated by their media conglomerates. As such, a future study that: a) further examines media conglomerates and the power dynamic that ensues when influences external to the ruling class raise the voice in the social sphere, b) assesses how these external influences aid in framing issues that are centered (and neglected) by the media – could serve to provide insight on the effectiveness of the “flax” method (fourth filter).

The hypothesis proposed by Herman and Chomsky (1988), which asserts that the media will never legitimize ideas or positions that do not have some representation among the elite, seems virtually ironclad, and is well nested in the political economic assessment of media structuring, as first proposed by Karl Marx. These suppositions can hardly be dismissed as “conspiracy theory”, especially in light of the revelation that media models are based on a “free market” analysis that is not reliant on conspiracy (McChesney, 1989), but is heavily dependent on profitability.

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